Precalculus II

An Original Ten-Week Course Reader

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1 Angles, Rotation, and the Unit Circle

This week's central question: How can we turn rotation into coordinates? The answer begins with the natural geometry of a circle.

1.1 Angles measure turning

An angle records a rotation from one ray to another. Counterclockwise rotations are positive, and clockwise rotations are negative. A rotation can exceed one full revolution. For example, 450° and 90° have the same terminal ray.

Definition 1.1. Two angles are *coterminal* if they have the same initial and terminal rays. They differ by an integer multiple of 360°, or 2π radians.

Example 1.1. A positive coterminal angle for -50° is $-50^\circ + 360^\circ = 310^\circ$.

1.2 Why radians are natural

For a circle of radius r with intercepted arc length s, define the radian measure $\theta = s/r$. This is a ratio of lengths. A full circumference is $2\pi r$, so one revolution measures 2π radians:

$$\boxed{\theta = \frac{s}{r}}, \qquad 180^\circ = \pi \text{ radians}.$$

Example 1.2. Convert 150° to radians: $150(\pi/180) = 5\pi/6$. Convert $7\pi/4$ radians to degrees: $(7\pi/4)(180/\pi) = 315^\circ$.

Try it. Convert 225° to radians and $-\pi/3$ radians to degrees, and sketch their terminal rays.

1.3 Arc length and angular speed

Rearrange the definition of radian measure to obtain $s = r\theta$. If rotation through θ takes time t, angular speed is $\omega = \theta/t$ and tangential speed is $v = r\omega$.

Example 1.3. A wheel of radius 0.4 m turns through $3\pi/2$ radians. A point on its rim travels $s = 0.4(3\pi/2) = 0.6\pi$ m.

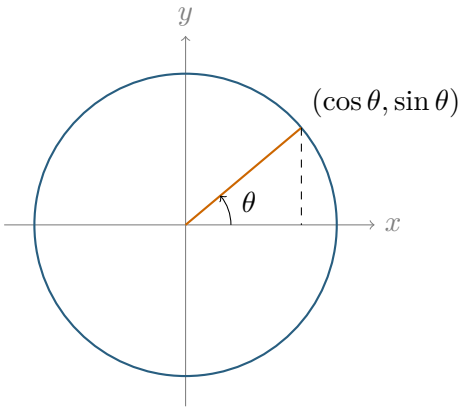
Try it. A Ferris wheel of radius 12 m makes one revolution every 40 s. Find its angular speed and a passenger's tangential speed.

1.4 Rotation becomes coordinates

Take a circle of radius 1 centered at the origin. The point at angle θ, measured from the positive x-axis, has coordinates

$$\boxed{(x, y) = (\cos\theta, \sin\theta)}.$$

Cosine is the horizontal coordinate and sine is the vertical coordinate. Because the point lies on $x^2 + y^2 = 1$, we get $\cos^2\theta + \sin^2\theta = 1$.



1.5 Reference angles and periodicity

Special angles arise from right triangles:

θ	$\cos\theta$	$\sin\theta$
0	1	0
$\pi/6$	$\sqrt{3}/2$	$1/2$
$\pi/4$	$\sqrt{2}/2$	$\sqrt{2}/2$
$\pi/3$	$1/2$	$\sqrt{3}/2$
$\pi/2$	0	1

The reference angle supplies the absolute values in every quadrant; the quadrant gives the signs.

Example 1.4. At $5\pi/6$, the reference angle is $\pi/6$ and the point is in quadrant II, so $\cos(5\pi/6) = -\sqrt{3}/2$ and $\sin(5\pi/6) = 1/2$.

After one full revolution the point returns to its previous position:

$$\sin(\theta + 2\pi) = \sin\theta, \qquad \cos(\theta + 2\pi) = \cos\theta.$$

This geometric periodicity will become the foundation of sinusoidal graphs.

1.6 Exercises

1. Convert $-135°$ and $300°$ to radians.
2. Convert $11\pi/6$ and $-5\pi/4$ to degrees.
3. Find an angle in $[0, 2\pi)$ coterminal with $19\pi/6$.
4. A circle of radius 8 cm subtends an angle of $5\pi/12$. Find the arc length.
5. A turntable makes $33\frac{1}{3}$ revolutions per minute. Find angular speed in radians per second.
6. Explain why sine and cosine must lie between -1 and 1.
7. Find unit-circle coordinates at $2\pi/3$, $5\pi/4$, and $11\pi/6$.
8. A Ferris wheel has radius 10 m and center $(0, 12)$. Write a rider's coordinates after turning through θ from the rightmost point.

Looking ahead. Next week we extend sine and cosine to the remaining four trigonometric functions.

2 The Six Trigonometric Functions

Central question. How do six functions arise naturally from the same moving point on a circle?

2.1 From a point to six functions

Last week we studied the unit-circle point $P = (x, y) = (\cos\theta, \sin\theta)$. The two coordinates determine four additional ratios whenever the denominators are nonzero:

$$\sin\theta = y, \quad \cos\theta = x, \quad \tan\theta = \frac{y}{x},$$
$$\csc\theta = \frac{1}{y}, \quad \sec\theta = \frac{1}{x}, \quad \cot\theta = \frac{x}{y}.$$

These are not six unrelated measurements. They are six different ways of reading the same geometric information.

Definition 2.1. The *tangent* function is $\tan\theta = \sin\theta/\cos\theta$ where $\cos\theta \neq 0$. The functions csc, sec, cot are the reciprocals of sin, cos, tan respectively, wherever defined.

Example 2.1. At $\theta = \pi/3$ the circle point is $(1/2, \sqrt{3}/2)$. Thus $\tan\theta = \sqrt{3}$, $\sec\theta = 2$, $\csc\theta = 2/\sqrt{3} = 2\sqrt{3}/3$, and $\cot\theta = 1/\sqrt{3} = \sqrt{3}/3$.

2.2 Signs and the quadrants

The coordinate signs determine every trig-function sign. In quadrant I both coordinates are positive; in II, only sine is positive; in III, tangent is positive because both coordinates are negative; and in IV, only cosine is positive. Reciprocal functions have the same signs as their corresponding original functions.

Example 2.2. For $\theta = 5\pi/4$, the reference angle is $\pi/4$ and $P = (-\sqrt{2}/2, -\sqrt{2}/2)$. Therefore $\tan\theta = 1$, $\sec\theta = -\sqrt{2}$, and $\csc\theta = -\sqrt{2}$.

2.3 Where are the functions undefined?

Division by zero has no meaning. In particular, $\tan\theta$ and $\sec\theta$ do not exist where $\cos\theta = 0$, at $\pi/2 + k\pi$. Similarly $\cot\theta$ and $\csc\theta$ do not exist where $\sin\theta = 0$, at $k\pi$, for any integer k. The word *undefined* matters: an undefined value is not the number zero.

Try it. Find all six trig-function values at $\theta = 3\pi/2$, identifying every undefined value.

2.4 Right triangles are a special case

For an acute angle θ in a right triangle, scale the triangle so its hypotenuse has length 1. The opposite and adjacent sides then give the coordinates $\sin\theta$ and $\cos\theta$. Restoring a general hypotenuse h gives

$$\sin\theta = \frac{\text{opposite}}{h}, \quad \cos\theta = \frac{\text{adjacent}}{h}, \quad \tan\theta = \frac{\text{opposite}}{\text{adjacent}}.$$

The unit circle is more general than the right-triangle definitions: it handles negative angles, obtuse angles, and angles exceeding a full revolution.

Example 2.3. A ramp rises 1.5 meters over a horizontal run of 6 meters. Its angle of inclination satisfies $\tan\theta = 1.5/6 = 1/4$. Therefore $\theta = \arctan(1/4) \approx 14.0°$.

2.5 Special angles without memorizing a disconnected table

An equilateral triangle of side 2 splits into two right triangles with sides $1, \sqrt{3}, 2$. This produces $\sin 30^\circ = 1/2$ and $\cos 30^\circ = \sqrt{3}/2$. A square of side 1 has diagonal $\sqrt{2}$, producing $\sin 45^\circ = \cos 45^\circ = \sqrt{2}/2$.



2.6 Applications: orientation and measurement

Suppose an observer stands 40 m from the foot of a vertical tower. The angle of elevation to its top is 35°. The tower's height h satisfies

$$\tan 35^\circ = \frac{h}{40}, \qquad h = 40 \tan 35^\circ \approx 28.0 \text{ m}.$$

Here the tangent function links an angle to a ratio of lengths. Always sketch the physical situation and label which distances are opposite and adjacent before calculating.

2.7 Exercises

1. At $\theta = 2\pi/3$, find all six functions exactly.
2. At $\theta = 7\pi/4$, find $\tan, \cot, \sec, \csc$.
3. Explain geometrically why $\tan(\pi/2)$ is undefined.
4. For which angles in $[0, 2\pi)$ is $\csc\theta$ undefined?
5. A right triangle has opposite side 5 and adjacent side 12. Find all six trig ratios exactly.
6. A ladder leans against a wall, reaching 8 m high. Its foot is 3 m from the wall. Find the angle with the ground.
7. A drone is viewed at an elevation angle of 28° from a point 75 m horizontally from the point below it. Estimate its altitude.
8. Show that $\sin^2\theta + \cos^2\theta = 1$ implies $1 + \tan^2\theta = \sec^2\theta$ wherever $\cos\theta \neq 0$.

3 Periodic Functions and Their Graphs

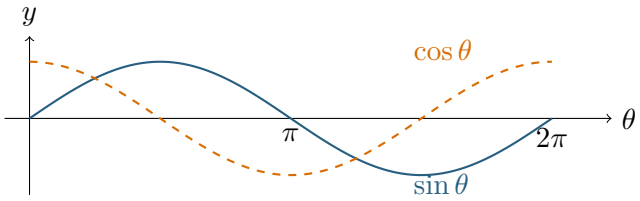
Central question. How does rotation become a repeating signal, and how can we recover the motion from a graph?

3.1 The circle makes a wave

For a point traveling around the unit circle with angle θ, its vertical coordinate is $y = \sin\theta$ and its horizontal coordinate is $x = \cos\theta$. Each revolution restores the same coordinates. Hence

$$\sin(\theta + 2\pi) = \sin\theta, \qquad \cos(\theta + 2\pi) = \cos\theta.$$

The *period* is the smallest positive input change that repeats the full function. Both sine and cosine have period 2π. Sine starts at 0 and initially rises; cosine starts at 1.



3.2 Amplitude and vertical translation

Consider $y = A\sin x + D$. Its midline is $y = D$, its amplitude is $|A|$, and its range is $[D - |A|, D + |A|]$. A negative A reflects the wave across the midline.

Example 3.1. The function $y = 3\sin x - 2$ has amplitude 3, midline $y = -2$, maximum 1, and minimum -5.

3.3 Period and horizontal scaling

For $y = \sin(Bx)$ with $B \neq 0$, one full cycle occurs when Bx changes by 2π; the period is $T = 2\pi/|B|$.

Example 3.2. The graph of $y = \cos(4x)$ repeats every $\pi/2$ units of input.

When x denotes time measured in seconds, the quantity $|B|$ is angular frequency in radians per second, and ordinary frequency is $f = 1/T = |B|/(2\pi)$ cycles per second.

3.4 Phase shift

A useful general form is

$$\boxed{y = A\sin(B(x - C)) + D}.$$

Here C is the horizontal shift, D the midline, $|A|$ the amplitude, and $2\pi/|B|$ the period. We should distinguish $B(x - C)$ from $Bx - C$: factoring first prevents an incorrect phase shift.

Example 3.3. For $y = 2\sin(3x - \pi) + 1 = 2\sin(3(x - \pi/3)) + 1$, the period is $2\pi/3$, the shift is $\pi/3$ to the right, the amplitude is 2, and the midline is 1.

3.5 Five landmark points

Rather than sketching a sinusoid by guesswork, divide one period into four equal intervals. For $A > 0$, sine begins on the midline, rises to a maximum after one quarter-period, returns to the midline, reaches a minimum, then returns to the midline. A negative amplitude reverses the rises and falls.

Try it. Find five landmark points of $y = -2\cos(\pi(x-1)) + 3$, showing one entire period.

3.6 Models of repeating motion

A Ferris wheel has radius 9 m, its center is 11 m above ground, and it makes one revolution every 30 s. If a passenger begins at the rightmost position and travels counterclockwise, their height is

$$h(t) = 11 + 9\sin\left(\frac{2\pi}{30}t\right).$$

Its amplitude is 9 m, midline is 11 m, and period is 30 s. A sinusoidal model can describe a wheel, a spring, a tide, or a musical tone, provided its parameters actually correspond to the chosen physical quantities.

3.7 Tangent and reciprocal graphs

The tangent function repeats after π, not 2π, because both sine and cosine change sign after a half turn and their ratio remains the same:

$$\tan(x + \pi) = \tan x.$$

Tangent has vertical asymptotes at $x = \pi/2 + k\pi$. The secant and cosecant graphs arise as reciprocals of cosine and sine; their breaks occur wherever the respective denominator is zero.

3.8 Exercises

1. Find the amplitude, midline, period, and range of $y = -4\sin(2x) + 1$.

2. Rewrite $y = 3\cos(5x - \pi) + 2$ in shifted form and identify the phase shift.

3. Give five landmark points for $y = 2\sin(x - \pi/2)$.

4. Explain why $y = \sin(2x)$ completes two periods on $[0, 2\pi]$.

5. A wheel of radius 6 m rotates once every 24 seconds. Its center is 8 m above the ground. Model the rider's height when starting at the rightmost point.

6. Identify the vertical asymptotes of $y = \tan(2x)$ on $[0, 2\pi)$.

7. Sketch one period of $y = 2\sec x$ and indicate all discontinuities.

8. Explain how you can determine amplitude and midline directly from observed maximum and minimum values.

4 Inverse Trigonometry and Identities

Central question: How can we recover an angle from its trigonometric value, and how do we prove two expressions represent the same function?

4.1 An inverse is not a reciprocal

The notation $\sin^{-1} x$ means the inverse function $\arcsin x$. It does not mean $1/\sin x = \csc x$. The inverse answers an angle question; the reciprocal answers a ratio question.

Sine is periodic, so an inverse function requires choosing an interval on which sine is one-to-one. We use $[-\pi/2, \pi/2]$. In exactly the same way, cosine uses $[0, \pi]$ and tangent uses $(-\pi/2, \pi/2)$.

$f(x)$	Domain	Range
$\arcsin x$	$[-1, 1]$	$[-\pi/2, \pi/2]$
$\arccos x$	$[-1, 1]$	$[0, \pi]$
$\arctan x$	$\mathbb{R}$	$(-\pi/2, \pi/2)$

Example 4.1. $\arcsin(1/2) = \pi/6$, $\arccos(-1/2) = 2\pi/3$, and $\arctan(-1) = -\pi/4$.

Example 4.2. $\arcsin(\sin(5\pi/6)) = \pi/6$, not $5\pi/6$, because the inverse reports its principal value.

4.2 Compositions and triangle geometry

The identity $\sin(\arcsin x) = x$ holds for $-1 \le x \le 1$, but $\arcsin(\sin\theta) = \theta$ only for θ in the principal range. Suppose $\theta = \arctan(3/4)$. Then a right triangle has legs $3, 4$ and hypotenuse 5, so

$$\sin(\arctan(3/4)) = \frac{3}{5}.$$

4.3 An identity is true throughout its domain

From the unit-circle equation we obtain

$$\boxed{\sin^2 x + \cos^2 x = 1}.$$

Dividing by $\cos^2 x$ (only where $\cos x \neq 0$) gives $1 + \tan^2 x = \sec^2 x$. Dividing by $\sin^2 x$ gives $1 + \cot^2 x = \csc^2 x$ where $\sin x \neq 0$.

Example 4.3. For $\sin x \neq 0$,

$$\frac{1 - \cos^2 x}{\sin x} = \frac{\sin^2 x}{\sin x} = \sin x.$$

This is an algebraic proof on the shared domain, not a numerical check at a few inputs.

4.4 Angle addition and double angles

Two successive plane rotations produce the sum identities

$$\cos(\alpha + \beta) = \cos\alpha\cos\beta - \sin\alpha\sin\beta,$$
$$\sin(\alpha + \beta) = \sin\alpha\cos\beta + \cos\alpha\sin\beta.$$

Set $\beta = -\gamma$ for difference identities and $\beta = \alpha$ for double-angle identities:

$$\sin(2x) = 2\sin x\cos x, \qquad \cos(2x) = \cos^2 x - \sin^2 x = 1 - 2\sin^2 x.$$

Example 4.4. $\sin(75^\circ) = \sin(45^\circ + 30^\circ) = (\sqrt{6} + \sqrt{2})/4$.

4.5 Applications: measured angles

An observation of a tower from 40 m away gives $\tan\theta = 3/4$. The elevation angle is $\arctan(3/4) \approx 36.9°$, while the height is exactly $40(3/4) = 30$ m. Inverse functions recover angles; ratios can often recover distances directly.

4.6 Exercises

1. Evaluate exactly $\arcsin(-\sqrt{2}/2)$ and $\arctan(\sqrt{3})$.
2. Explain why $\arcsin(\sin(3\pi/4)) \neq 3\pi/4$.
3. Find $\cos(\arcsin(5/13))$ with a triangle.
4. Find $\sin(\arctan(-2))$ exactly, including its sign.
5. Prove $(\sec^2 x - 1)/\tan x = \tan x$ on its domain.
6. Prove $(\sin x + \cos x)^2 = 1 + \sin(2x)$.
7. Calculate $\cos(75°)$ exactly by angle addition.
8. Express $\cos(2x)$ using $\sin x$ alone.

5 Trigonometric Equations and Applications

Central question. When a trigonometric function has a prescribed value, how can we find *all* the angles that produce it? How can we use angles to solve triangles that are not right triangles?

5.1 A first equation on the unit circle

Consider $\sin x = 1/2$. The unit circle has two points whose vertical coordinate is $1/2$, at $x = \pi/6$ and $x = 5\pi/6$. Every full revolution reproduces these points:

$$\boxed{x = \frac{\pi}{6} + 2\pi k \quad \text{or} \quad x = \frac{5\pi}{6} + 2\pi k, \qquad k \in \mathbb{Z}.}$$

An inverse trigonometric function gives one principal angle, not necessarily every solution. The unit circle and periodicity give the complete answer.

Example 5.1. Solve $\cos x = -\sqrt{2}/2$ for $0 \le x < 2\pi$. The solutions are $3\pi/4$ and $5\pi/4$.

5.2 Equations with transformations

To solve $\sin(2x) = \sqrt{3}/2$ on $[0, 2\pi)$, first solve for $u = 2x$ on $[0, 4\pi)$. We obtain $u = \pi/3, 2\pi/3, 7\pi/3, 8\pi/3$ and therefore

$$x = \frac{\pi}{6}, \frac{\pi}{3}, \frac{7\pi}{6}, \frac{4\pi}{3}.$$

A changed frequency changes how many full cycles fit into the requested interval.

Example 5.2. Solve $2\cos x - 1 = 0$ on $[0, 2\pi)$. Isolating cosine gives $\cos x = 1/2$, hence $x = \pi/3$ or $5\pi/3$.

5.3 Factoring and checking domains

An equation may contain more than one trig function. Algebraic techniques still work:

$$2\sin^2 x - \sin x = 0 \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \sin x(2\sin x - 1) = 0.$$

On $[0, 2\pi)$ we obtain $x = 0, \pi, \pi/6, 5\pi/6$. Dividing by $\sin x$ at the outset would have lost two solutions.

5.4 Trigonometric identities in equations

For example, $2\cos^2 x - 1 = 0$ becomes $\cos^2 x = 1/2$, hence $\cos x = \pm\sqrt{2}/2$. There are four solutions on $[0, 2\pi)$. Using identities can make equations simpler, but each transformation should preserve the original domain.

5.5 Solving triangles: notation

Write the vertices of a triangle as A, B, C, and the opposite side lengths as a, b, c. Its angles satisfy $A + B + C = \pi$. For right triangles, the six trig ratios are enough. For oblique triangles, two laws extend our tools.

Definition 5.1 (Law of Sines)**.** For every nondegenerate triangle,

$$\boxed{\frac{a}{\sin A} = \frac{b}{\sin B} = \frac{c}{\sin C}.}$$

Example 5.3. A triangle has $A = 40°$, $B = 65°$, and $a = 9$ cm. Since $C = 75°$, the Law of Sines gives $b = 9\sin 65°/\sin 40° \approx 12.69$ cm.

5.6 The ambiguous SSA case

Given two sides and a nonincluded angle (SSA), the Law of Sines may produce zero, one, or two triangles. If $\sin B = s$, both $B = \arcsin s$ and $B = \pi - \arcsin s$ must be considered, and each candidate must fit with the known angle A in a triangle.

Example 5.4. Suppose $A = 30^\circ$, $a = 5$ and $b = 8$. Then $\sin B = 8 \sin 30^\circ / 5 = 0.8$. Both $B \approx 53.13^\circ$ and $B \approx 126.87^\circ$ are consistent with $A + B < 180^\circ$, so two distinct triangles exist.

Definition 5.2 (Law of Cosines)**.** For a triangle with sides a, b, c opposite angles A, B, C,

$$\boxed{c^2 = a^2 + b^2 - 2ab\cos C.}$$

When $C = 90^\circ$ this becomes the Pythagorean theorem. The cosine term measures how the included angle modifies the length of the opposite side.

Example 5.5. Two sides of a triangle are 7 m and 10 m, with included angle 60°. The opposite side satisfies $c^2 = 49 + 100 - 140(1/2) = 79$, so $c = \sqrt{79}$ m.

5.7 Applied modeling and interpretation

Two sensors observe a distant object from different locations. The baseline and their sight angles make a triangle. The Law of Sines can recover an inaccessible distance if we know a side and two angles. Always include the diagram, angle units, and a reasonableness check.

5.8 Exercises

1. Solve $\sin x = -\sqrt{3}/2$ for $0 \le x < 2\pi$.
2. Solve $2\sin(3x) = 1$ for $0 \le x < 2\pi$; find every solution.
3. Solve $2\cos^2 x - \cos x = 0$ on $[0, 2\pi)$.
4. Solve $\tan x = -1$ for all real x.
5. A triangle has $A = 35^\circ$, $B = 80^\circ$ and $a = 12$. Find C and b.
6. For $A = 30^\circ$, $a = 5$, $b = 8$, calculate both possible values of C in the SSA case.
7. Find the third side of a triangle when two sides have length 6 and 9 and their included angle is 120°.
8. Explain why the Law of Cosines becomes the Pythagorean theorem for right triangles.

6 Vectors and Geometric Applications

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